

Mastery of Register

C2 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

Register is the level of formality and the specific conventions of grammar and vocabulary appropriate to a context. C2 speakers can recast the same content across academic, legal, journalistic, casual and technical styles at will.

- a) Academic register — nominalization, passive voice, hedging modals, precise connectors, avoidance of contractions and first person where possible.

Casual: We found that people work better in teams.

Academic: The findings indicate that collaborative work environments enhance productivity.

- b) Legal register — highly formal, precise, often uses archaic connectors (hereinafter, notwithstanding, pursuant to, shall for obligation), long compound sentences, and avoids ambiguity through repetition of exact terms rather than pronouns.

The Tenant shall, pursuant to Clause 4 of this Agreement, provide written notice no fewer than thirty (30) days prior to termination.

- c) Journalistic register — concise, front-loaded with the most important information (lead paragraph), attributed claims ("according to," "sources say"), active voice for readability, short paragraphs.

Officials confirmed on Tuesday that the bridge would remain closed for repairs, according to a statement released by the transport authority.

- d) Casual/conversational register — contractions, phrasal verbs, ellipsis, informal connectors (so, anyway, kind of), direct address, shorter sentences.

So basically, they're closing the bridge for repairs — no idea for how long, though.

- e) Technical register — precise domain-specific terminology, imperative mood for instructions, passive voice for procedures, minimal hedging.

Insert the cable into port A before powering on the device. Do not exceed the rated voltage.

Recasting the same information across these registers means adjusting: sentence length and complexity, verb voice (active/passive), vocabulary formality, use of contractions/pronouns, and how directly claims are attributed or hedged.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. Academic: The data suggest a strong correlation between sleep quality and cognitive performance.
- 2. Legal: The Purchaser shall remit payment in full within thirty (30) days of the invoice date.
- 3. Journalistic: Sales fell sharply in the third quarter, the company revealed on Monday.
- 4. Casual: Sales basically tanked last quarter — nobody really knows why yet.
- 5. Technical: Ensure the device is disconnected from the power supply before servicing.
- 6. Academic: It could be argued that the policy failed to address the underlying causes of inequality.
- 7. Legal: Notwithstanding the foregoing, either party may terminate this Agreement upon written notice.
- 8. Journalistic: Residents were left without power for several hours after Tuesday's storm, officials said.
- 9. Casual: We were literally stuck without power for hours after that storm — it was chaos.
- 10. Technical: Do not operate the equipment if the safety guard is missing or damaged.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect (academic): I think the results are pretty surprising.

Correct: The results are somewhat unexpected. / It could be argued that the results are surprising.

Why: Academic register avoids first-person opinion markers ("I think") and casual intensifiers ("pretty") — use hedged, impersonal phrasing instead.

- 2. Incorrect (legal): The company will has to pay the fine.

Correct: The Company shall be liable to pay the fine.

Why: Legal register uses "shall" for binding obligation, formal capitalized defined terms (the Company), and correct modal grammar.

- 3. Incorrect (journalistic): It is reported by some sources, allegedly, that the mayor did resign, according to reports.

Correct: The mayor resigned on Tuesday, according to sources close to city hall.

Why: Journalistic style avoids redundant hedging/attribution stacked together — attribute once, clearly and concisely.

- 4. Incorrect (technical): You should maybe try disconnecting the cable if it feels warm.

Correct: Disconnect the cable immediately if it becomes warm to the touch.

Why: Technical/instructional register uses direct imperatives, not hedged suggestions.

- 5. Incorrect (casual): I would like to inform you that I am unable to attend due to a prior commitment.

Correct (casual): Sorry, can't make it — something else came up.

Why: This overly formal phrasing is mismatched with a casual context; casual register favors contractions and short, direct phrasing.

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (choose the word/phrase that fits the register indicated)
- 1. (Legal) The Tenant ____ (will/shall) vacate the premises by the end of the lease term.
- 2. (Academic) The findings ____ (show/kinda show) a clear pattern across all groups studied.
- 3. (Journalistic) The company confirmed the layoffs ____ (in a statement/basically) released on Friday.
- 4. (Casual) ____ (I regret to inform you/Sorry), I can't make it tonight.
- 5. (Technical) ____ (Please consider disconnecting/Disconnect) the power source before opening the case.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (rewrite the sentence in the register indicated)
- 1. "The plan didn't work out." → Rewrite in academic register.
- 2. "The tenant needs to pay rent by the 1st of the month or else." → Rewrite in legal register.
- 3. "The mayor said the roads will be fixed soon." → Rewrite in journalistic register (add attribution/lead style).
- 4. "One must exercise caution when the device is in operation." → Rewrite in casual register.
- 5. "We think the marketing campaign kind of failed." → Rewrite in academic register.
- C. Error Correction (identify the register mismatch and fix it)
- 1. (Legal contract) The Buyer will maybe pay within 30 days.
- 2. (Academic essay) I feel like the evidence is pretty convincing, honestly.
- 3. (Technical manual) You might want to think about turning off the machine before cleaning it.
- 4. (Journalism) It is alleged, allegedly, according to some reports, that the CEO may have resigned.
- 5. (Casual text to a friend) I regret to inform you that I am running late.
- D. Guided Production
- 1. Take a piece of casual news you'd share with a friend (e.g., "my flight got cancelled") and rewrite it in journalistic register.
- 2. Rewrite the same idea in academic register, using nominalization and hedging.
- 3. Rewrite the same idea in technical/instructional register, as if writing a procedure.
- 4. Rewrite the same idea in legal register, as if it were a clause in a contract.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
- 1. shall
- 2. show
- 3. in a statement
- 4. Sorry
- 5. Disconnect
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (sample answers)
- 1. The plan did not achieve its intended outcomes.
- 2. The Tenant shall remit rent payment no later than the first day of each calendar month; failure to do so shall constitute a breach of this Agreement.
- 3. The roads will be repaired soon, the mayor said on Tuesday.
- 4. Careful — this thing's running, so watch out.
- 5. It could be argued that the marketing campaign did not meet its objectives.
- C. Error Correction
- 1. The Buyer shall pay within thirty (30) days.
- 2. The evidence appears to be convincing.
- 3. Turn off the machine before cleaning it.
- 4. The CEO is reported to have resigned, according to sources.
- 5. Running late, sorry!
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
- 1. Journalistic: Passengers faced significant delays on Tuesday after an unexpected cancellation disrupted several flights, according to airline officials.
- 2. Academic: The cancellation of the flight resulted in considerable disruption to the traveler's itinerary.
- 3. Technical: In the event of flight cancellation, proceed to the nearest service desk and present your booking confirmation.
- 4. Legal: In the event that the Carrier cancels the scheduled flight, the Passenger shall be entitled to rebooking or a full refund, at the Passenger's discretion.